

How can we conceptualize the government planning, implementation and reporting cycle?

An overall description of DoView Planning has been provided in The Five Steps in DoView Planning Tool (A1). This tool looks in more detail at how government planning is undertaken. It breaks the five steps up into a more detailed set of steps. Government planning systems can be difficult to understand because the way in which they plan, implement and report is determined by various conventions and regulations. It is useful to have a generic framework for simplifying and thinking about how governments typically undertake the cycle of strategy, planning, implementation, and reporting. Once we have this framework, we can use it to understand how a particular government's system works. We can do this by looking at each element in the cycle and determining whether the particular government has a corresponding step in its cycle and whether this step is working adequately. If not, then the step needs to be introduced into that government's cycle, or if it is present but not working, it needs to be fixed.

This tool sets out the Government Planning, Implementation and Reporting Cycle (A2). The first step is defining outcomes. There are three types of outcomes that need to be defined. Neglecting any of these three types can cause problems. The first is politicians' outcomes and the steps they think are necessary to achieve the change agenda outlined in their party manifesto. The second is citizens' priority outcomes that need to be captured and integrated into government planning. The third is the business-as-usual work that government agencies need to undertake regardless of which set of politicians is in power.

The cycle then goes on to include priority setting, identifying deliverables (outputs), performance measurement, trade-off discussions, allocating funding, providing the services that have been funded, checking that funding has been spent appropriately, reporting back, and improving performance by taking into account information from monitoring and evaluation.

The cycle then leads back to its starting point and then, when the next planning period starts, politicians will reassess their outcomes once again, and so the cycle will recommence. Because it captures the whole scope of government planning, implementation and reporting, this framework has been used as a way of broadly grouping the tools in this book.